

EYEWITNESS June 19, 1864

The **Duel** of the *Alabama* and the *Kearsarge*

Captained by Raphael Semmes, the CSS *Alabama* proved to be the Confederacy's most formidable commerce raider. After capturing 64 U.S. merchant vessels—many in international waters—the *Alabama*'s successful career as a raider came to an end when she was sunk during a duel with the USS *Kearsarge* off the coast of Cherbourg, France, in June 1864.

“By this time, we were distant about one mile from each other, when I opened on him with solid shot, to which he replied ... It became necessary to fight in a circle; the two ships steaming around a common center, and preserving a distance from each other ... When we got within good shell range, we opened upon him with shell ... The firing now became very hot, and the enemy's shot, and shell soon began to tell upon our hull, knocking down, killing, and disabling a number of men, at the same time, in different parts of the ship. Perceiving that our shell, though apparently exploding against the enemy's sides, were doing him but little damage, I returned to solid-shot firing ...

After the lapse of about one hour and ten minutes, our ship was ascertained to be in a sinking condition, the enemy's shell having exploded in our sides, and between decks, opening large apertures through which the water rushed with great rapidity.”

CAPTAIN RAPHAEL SEMMES OF THE CSS *ALABAMA*, FROM HIS OFFICIAL REPORT OF THE ENGAGEMENT TO FLAG OFFICER SAMUEL BARRON, JUNE 21, 1864

“The action was now fairly begun ... A shot from an early broadside carried away the spanker-gaff of the enemy, and caused his ensign to come down by the run. This incident was regarded as a favorable omen by the men who cheered ... The *Alabama* returned to solid shot, and soon after fired both shot and shell to the end. The firing of the *Alabama* was rapid and wild, getting better near the close; that of the *Kearsarge* was deliberate, accurate, and almost from the beginning productive of dismay, destruction, and death ...